

On messages

DELPH-IN, Fefor

14 June 2006

Messages in MRS

- MRS for each utterance includes at least one message
Three-way distinction: proposition, question, command
- MRS for some utterances include multiple messages
- In Matrix grammars, each message has unique ARG0 event
- Experiments in adding topic and passive marking to messages

Problems with messages

- Inconsistent naming conventions in Matrix vs. RMRS
- Lack of well-understood theory of messages in semantics
- Slippery slopes in deciding when to introduce a message

The dog that was annoyed by a cat barked.

The dog annoyed by a cat barked.

The annoyed dog barked.

The angry dog barked.
- Challenges in defining language-independent Matrix phrase types
- Difficulty in guaranteeing topmost message with scopal modifier

Probably the dog barked.
- Complication for verbs that select a sentential complement

ERG uses CONT.MSG attribute for *insist* vs. *wonder*

Modest proposal: eliminate messages completely

- Drop message EPs from RELS
- Draw three-way distinction with MOOD attribute on events
Already have one-to-one correspondence for msg and event
Proposed values of MOOD: *prop*, *ques*, *comm*
- Develop CONTEXT-based approach to topic marking, etc.
- Full conversion of ERG took two weeks